BHAVANI T.N., *30*

The former instructor took up competitive cross-country skiing only in 2020. After international success in 2023, Bhavani T.N. became the first Indian cross-country skier to pick up a medal at an F.I.S. event in September. She put on a stellar show at the National Cross-Country Skiing Championships in Chile, with a bronze in the 5km interval start and the 1.3km sprint.



ARIF KHAN, *35*

The flag-bearer of Indian winter sports, Arif Khan became the first Indian to qualify for two events at the same Winter Games in Beijing in 2022. He took gold and bronze at the F.I.S. Alpine Slalom Race in the United Arab Emirates the following year, while finishing just outside of the podium places in the men's slalom at the F.I.S. Montenegro Cup in March this year.



—Shail Desai

SPORTS ▼

SWITCHING BATS

BASEBALL UNITED, THE FIRST PROFESSIONAL LEAGUE BRINGING THE SPORT TO SOUTH ASIA AND THE MIDDLE EAST, KICKS OFF NEXT MONTH



Most couldn't wrap their heads around Tushar Lalwani's decision to switch from cricket to baseball in the seventh grade. In baseball, he found a lot of transferable skills and the possibility of someday representing the country. That dream came true when he donned the Indian jersey at the Arab Classic in November last year.

> College players have been **scouted from across India** and worked with mentors over the years

Next month, Lalwani will be one of three Indian players to turn out for Mumbai Cobras in the inaugural edition of Baseball United, besides three other players of Indian origin. The four-team professional league is the brainchild of Kash Shaikh, John Miedreich and Major League Baseball legends like Barry Larkin, Mariano Rivera and Adrian Beltre, and was launched to bring the sport to the Middle East and South Asia.

Baseball United has tied up with the Amateur Baseball Federation of India to scout players from universities and colleges across the country. Over the past few years, prospects like Lalwani have been working remotely with mentors Carlos Mirabal and Vishnu Kalel.

The league gets underway on November 14 with a marquee clash in Dubai between Mumbai Cobras and Karachi Monarchs. Shaikh, chairman, CEO and co-founder, grew up in Houston, well aware of the India-Pakistan cricket rivalry through his Pakistani mother and Indian father. "There is no better environment to bring people together than sport," he says. "And we want to do it through baseball." ■

—Shail Desai